



INDIAN SOCIETY

MODULE - 7

CHALLENGES TO CULTURAL DIVERSITY

CULTURAL DIVERSITY

- 1 The term 'diversity' emphasizes differences rather than inequalities.
- 2 Communities in India are defined by cultural markers such as language, religion, sect, race or caste and this is called cultural diversity.
- 3 When these diverse communities are also part of a larger entity like a nation, then difficulties may be created by competition or conflict between them.



CULTURAL DIVERSITY CAN PRESENT TOUGH CHALLENGES

- 1 Cultural identities can arouse intense passions and are often able to mobilize large numbers of people.
- 2 When economic and social inequalities accompany cultural, things get more complicated.
- 3 Measures to address the inequalities or injustices suffered by one community can provoke opposition from other communities.
- 4 Situation is made worse when scarce resources like river waters, jobs or government funds have to be shared.



IMPORTANCE OF COMMUNITY IDENTITY

- 1 Community provides the language (our mother tongue) and the cultural values through which one comprehends the world. It also anchors the self-identity.
- 2 People feel a deep sense of security and satisfaction in belonging to communities in which their membership is entirely accidental. It gives emotional support and social bonding.
- 3 Expanding and overlapping circles of community ties (family, kinship, caste, ethnicity, language, region or religion) give meaning to one's social world.
- 4 Ascriptive identities and community feeling are universal.



IMPORTANCE OF COMMUNITY IDENTITY

- 5 Community identity is based on birth and 'belonging' are called 'ascriptive', that is, they are determined by the accidents of birth and do not involve any choice on the part of the individuals concerned.
- 6 Most ascriptive identities are very hard to shake off, even if we choose to disown them, others may continue to identify us by those very markers of belonging.



CULTURAL DIVERSITY AND THE INDIAN NATION-STATE

- 1** Indian nation-state is socially and culturally one of the most diverse countries of the world with a population of about 1.21 billion people.
- 2** The billion-plus people speak about 1,632 different languages and dialects.
- 3** Eighteen of these languages have been officially recognized and placed under the 8th Schedule of the Constitution, thus guaranteeing their legal status.
- 4** **In terms of religion**
 - About 80% of the population are Hindus, who in turn are regionally specific, plural in beliefs and practices, and divided by castes and languages.
 - About 13.4% of the population are Muslims, which makes India the world's third largest Muslim country after Indonesia and Pakistan.
 - The other major religious communities are Christians (2.3%), Sikhs (1.9%), Buddhists (0.8%) and Jains (0.4%).

CULTURAL DIVERSITY AND THE INDIAN NATION-STATE

- 5 The Constitution declares the state to be a secular state, but religion, language and other such factors are not banished from the public sphere.
- 6 By international standards, very strong constitutional protection is offered to minority religions.
- 7 India's problems have been more in the sphere of implementation and practice rather than laws or principles.



REGIONALISM IN THE INDIAN CONTEXT

- 1** Regionalism in India is rooted in
 - India's diversity of languages, cultures, tribes, and religions.
 - Geographical concentration of these identity markers in particular regions.
 - Instigated by a sense of regional deprivation.
- 2** Indian federalism has been a means of accommodating these regional sentiments.
- 3** After Independence, initially the Indian state continued with the British-Indian arrangement dividing India into large provinces (called 'presidencies') and princely states.
- 4** These were large multi-ethnic and multilingual provincial states constituting the major political-administrative units of a semi-federal state called the Union of India.



REGIONALISM IN THE INDIAN CONTEXT

5 For example, the old Bombay State (continuation of the Bombay Presidency) was a multilingual state of Marathi, Gujarati, Kannada and Konkani speaking people.

6 After the adoption of the Constitution, these were reorganized into ethno-linguistic States (Language coupled with regional and tribal identity and not religion) within the Indian union in response to strong popular agitations.

7 Far from undermining Indian unity, linguistic states have helped strengthen it.

8 It has proved to be perfectly consistent to be Kannadiga and Indian, Bengali and Indian, Tamil and Indian etc.



REGIONALISM IN THE INDIAN CONTEXT

- 9 However, this does not mean that all linguistic communities have got statehood.
- 10 For instance, in the creation of three new states in 2000, namely Chhattisgarh, Uttarakhand and Jharkhand, language did not play a prominent role.
- 11 Rather, a combination of ethnicity based on tribal identity, language, regional deprivation and ecology provided the basis for intense regionalism resulting in statehood.



REGIONALISM IN THE INDIAN CONTEXT

12 Respecting regional sentiments has to be backed up with an institutional structure that ensures their viability as relatively autonomous units within a larger federal structure.

- i** Schedule 7 of Indian constitution enabled it with exclusive state and concurrent lists.
- ii** State legislatures determine the composition of the upper house of Parliament, the Rajya Sabha.
- iii** Periodic committees and commissions that decide on Centre-State relations.
- iv** Finance Commission to decide on sharing of tax revenues between Centre and States.

- v** Five Year Plan involved detailed State Plans prepared by the State Planning Commissions of each state.



REGIONALISM IN THE INDIAN CONTEXT

- 13 On the whole the federal system has worked fairly well, though there remain many contentious issues.
- 14 Since the era of liberalization (i.e., since the 1990s) there is concern about increasing inter-regional economic and infrastructural inequalities.
- 15 With greater role for private investment in economic development, considerations of regional equity get diluted.
- 16 Unlike private industry, the government can give some consideration to regional equity and other social goals which need fresh public initiatives.



NATION-STATE AND RELIGION-RELATED ISSUES AND IDENTITIES

1 Issues relating to religious communities and religion-based identities may be broadly divided into two related groups:

a **The secularism–communalism set**

b **The minority–majority set**

2 Questions of secularism and communalism are about the state's relationship to religion and to political groupings that invoke religion as their primary identity.

3 Questions about minorities and majorities involve decisions on how the state is to treat different religious, ethnic or other communities that are unequal in terms of numbers and/or power (including social, economic and political power).



MINORITY RIGHTS AND NATION BUILDING

- 1 In Indian nationalism, the dominant trend was marked by an inclusive and democratic vision.
- 2 Inclusive because it recognized diversity and plurality.
- 3 Democratic because it sought to do away with discrimination and exclusion and bring forth a just and equitable society.
- 4 Often there is a very strong tendency for the dominant group to assume that their culture or language or religion is synonymous with the nation state.

- 5 Hence, for a strong and democratic nation, special constitutional provisions are required to ensure the rights of all groups and those of minority groups in particular.



MINORITY RIGHTS AND NATION BUILDING

- 6 When the term 'minority' is used without qualification, it generally implies
- a relatively small but also disadvantaged group.
 - members of the minority form a collectivity.
 - they have a strong sense of group solidarity, a feeling of togetherness and belonging.
- 7
- Indian Muslims below SCs and STs with respect to backwardness.
 - Poor representation in positions like the IAS, IPS and in the police.(Sachar report)
- 8 Religious or cultural minorities need special protection because of the demographic dominance of the majority.



MINORITY RIGHTS AND NATION BUILDING

- 9 Religious or cultural minorities – regardless of their economic or social position – are politically vulnerable.
- 10 They must face the risk that the majority community will capture political power and use the state machinery to suppress their religious or cultural institutions, ultimately forcing them to abandon their distinctive identity.
- 11 Any forcible imposition of a language or religion on any group of people in India weakens national unity which is based upon a recognition of differences.
- 12 Indian nationalism recognizes this, and the Indian Constitution affirms this.



RELATIVE SIZE AND DISTRIBUTION OF RELIGIOUS MINORITIES

- 1 Hindus account for about 80% of the total population according to the 2011 Census.
- 2 The Hindu population is four times larger than the combined population of all other minority religions.
- 3 However, this can also be misleading because Hindus are not a homogenous group and are divided by caste.
- 4 The Muslims are the largest religious minority in India. They are scattered all over the country, constitute a majority in Jammu and Kashmir and have sizeable pockets in West Bengal, Uttar Pradesh, Kerala, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and Rajasthan.



RELATIVE SIZE AND DISTRIBUTION OF RELIGIOUS MINORITIES

5 Christians constitute around 2.3% of the population (27.8 million) and are scattered all over, with sizeable pockets in the north eastern and southern states.

6 The three Christian-majority states are all in the North East – Nagaland (88%), Mizoram (87%) and Meghalaya (74%). Sizeable proportions of Christians are also found in Goa (25%) and Kerala (18.4%).

7 The Sikhs constitute 1.7% of the population (21 million) and although they are found scattered across the country, they are concentrated in Punjab where they are in a majority (58%).



RELATIVE SIZE AND DISTRIBUTION OF RELIGIOUS MINORITIES

8 The highest proportion of Buddhists is found in Sikkim (27%) and Arunachal Pradesh (12%), while among the larger states Maharashtra has the highest share of Buddhists at 6%.

9 The highest concentrations of Jains are found in Maharashtra (1.3%), Delhi and Gujarat nearly 1 per cent each.



COMMUNIALISM

- 1 Communalism is an aggressive political ideology linked to religion.
- 2 It refers to aggressive chauvinism based on religious identity.
- 3 Chauvinism itself is an attitude that sees one's own group as the only legitimate or worthy group, with other groups being seen as inferior, illegitimate and opposed.
- 4 It is important to emphasize that communalism is about politics, not about religion.
- 5 One of the characteristic features of communalism is its claim that religious identity overrides everything else.
- 6 This has the effect of constructing large and diverse groups as singular and homogenous.



COMMUNIALISM

7 Communalism is an especially important issue in India because it has been a recurrent source of tension and violence.

8 Anti-Sikh riots of Delhi in 1984 , anti-Muslim violence in Gujarat in 2002, Rama Janma Bhoomi issue, Assaults based on alleged beef trade are some major communal events.

9 India has had a history of communal riots from pre-Independence times, often as a result of the divide-and-rule policy adopted by the colonial rulers.



COMMUNIALISM

- 10 But colonialism did not invent inter-community conflicts, there is also a long history of pre-colonial conflicts.
- 11 But India also has a long tradition of religious pluralism, ranging from peaceful co-existence to actual inter-mixing or syncretism, Multi-Culturalism and secularism.
- 12 This syncretic heritage is clearly evident in the devotional songs and poetry of the Bhakti and Sufi movements.



INDIAN SECULARISM

- i Implies equal respect for all religions - “Sarva Dharma Sambhava” (literally means that destination of the paths followed by all religions is the same, though the paths themselves may be different), rather than separation or distancing which is a concept of western secularism.
- ii It emphasizes on principled intervention by the state. For example, criminalization of triple talaq and women entry into sabarimalai temple.
- iii India does not have an official state religion.
- iv Constitution protects both individual and community rights under Fundamental rights



INDIAN SECULARISM

- 1** Universalization of citizenship rights and the induction of cultural pluralities into the democratic process of open and competitive politics would evolve new, civic equations among ethnic communities, and between them and the state.
- 2** These expectations may not have materialized in the manner expected. But ever since Independence, the people of India through election verdicts have repeatedly asserted their support for a secular Constitution and state.
- 3** Issues are created by the tension between the Indian state's simultaneous commitment to secularism as well as the protection of minorities.
- 4** But providing such protection immediately invites the accusation of favouritism or 'appeasement' of minorities.



INDIAN SECULARISM

- 5 These kinds of controversies become harder to solve when political parties and social movements develop a vested interest in keeping them alive.
- 6 In recent times, communalists of all religions have contributed to the deadlock.
- 7 The resurgence and newly acquired political power of the Hindu communalists has added a further dimension of complexity.
- 8 Clearly a lot needs to be done to improve our understanding of secularism as a principle and our practice of it as a policy.
- 9 Yet, India's Constitution and legal structure has proved to be reasonably effective in handling the problems created by various kinds of communalism.



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